

****Retracted File #001****

****Sergeant Joseph's audio journal*****

10:30 Am

Location:- Retracted

I clutched my sword tightly as the figure emerged from the shadows of the dark hallway. It was none other than the First Hero, a man known to be a 'hero' but known to us as the devil lurking in the shadows.

"I thought multi-trillionaires were supposed to be busy!" I shouted, trying to distract him. Before he could respond, Tara, my subordinate, attacked, her sword gleaming as she charged at him. Following her lead, all 16 of my squadron members rushed forward, leaving me as the only one holding back on the other end of the adamantine tunnel.

"Oh, you're approaching me? What's your plan, boy?" Charlie taunted, snapping his fingers. Instantly, a gust of wind knocked my squadron down.

"I thought Charlie only had annihilation skills like the Authority of Destruction and Cosmic Decide. What's this?" Tara yelled in frustration, glaring at me.

"I don't know, maybe he used his magic!" I responded, but Charlie's laughter cut through the tension.

"OMG, I can't even believe it, idiots! I just snapped my fingers, nothing more. Besides, what adult uses his full force against mere children?" His mocking tone stung, calling my squadron of seasoned fighters mere children.

Fueled by anger, my squadron forgot their families waiting for them and activated the auto-destruct on their uniforms. The resulting explosion was contained by the adamantite walls, but the heat was intense enough to melt flesh. As the smoke cleared, Charlie stood there, unfazed, blood splattered on the walls but not a single drop on him.

"This, my friend, is my ultimate ability: Chrono Destinatus. It destroys fate, timelines, rumors, myths, and even stories where I can be hurt. Just like here, it destroyed the fate of the bomb's shrapnel and heat touching me, and the fate of blood splattering on me. It's always active. It can even use the Authority of Destruction on its own to destroy vectors of incoming attacks. You can't hurt me, no one can," he said, gripping my collar.

If you're wondering how he got hold of my collar so quickly, so am I.

"So, who can hurt you?" I asked, daringly. The situation couldn't get worse.

"NOTHING! You see, my friend, you are a slave to God's game. An omniversal engine dictates everyone's fate across all timelines and universes. I destroy a fate, and that

engine rewrites it in my favor. There is no free will in this omniverse, except mine, obviously," he explained, seemingly sincere.

"Then why did you kill us? If you understand we are slaves, then why?" I screamed in desperation.

"Because even slaves should have a predator's instinct. I am someone you can't even dream of defeating, yet you tried, showcasing your bravado. I don't like it when slaves step up to their masters. Anyway, little boy, I could have prevented those bombs from exploding, but where's the fun in that? And don't bother looking for drawbacks to my power; there are none. Even GOD is sick of this. Also, I don't need to snap my fingers to activate my powers; I just do it for show," he said, snapping his fingers again.

Suddenly, the adamantine wall crumbled to powder, and our headquarters began to collapse. As I ran for my life, I knew it was hopeless; he wanted me to be buried under the debris and die slowly. His cruel smile haunted me, a reminder of why beings like him should never exist.

*** end of audio journal*****

"So what happened to sergeant Afterall he must be alive to narrate such detailed journal" "well he is alive alright with no arms or legs amputee because we couldn't save him on time " "How much do we know about this Charlie" "Not More then he speaks about himself"

(jerry pov)

"This is rather boring," I yelled at the empty blue wormhole in front of me. This whole wormhole thing was new to me, but I was getting used to it. "You guys are rather prepared. Is this a normal occurrence for the trio of the strongest?" I asked the organized trio: Liza, the Witch of Annihilation; Elfona, the Lady of Flowers; and Hecate, the Night's Sovereign.

"Well, we are the best," smiled Hecate, probably using her telepathy to read my mind just to emphasize her point.

"It's just our field experience, don't pay it any heed," said Elfona in her ever-sweet voice. Yep, I had perfect company for an ever-chilly night in the desert, just outside a creepy obsidian temple.

"Your inner thoughts are confusing me. Simply curious, why did the Almighty choose you again?" Hecate asked, grinning from ear to ear, showing her pristine teeth and fangs sharp enough to tear my skin at a moment's notice.

"Well, I was assured by Him that His choices are infallible, so put some faith in it," I replied, because I could not afford to lose the few connections, I had that mattered in a savage place like this.

"Why isn't it working?" I asked, directing my question to the ever-present teacher, Liza. She looked at me, raised her hand, gently arched herself, and said, "Portals work beyond the scope of time. Once opened by the summoner, it is common practice to stay there until the summoned appears."

As if on cue, the portal started fluctuating, having already consumed half my mana, which I knew courtesy of the magic index. "Well, sometimes half isn't enough, and you have to tough it out," yelled Hecate as she grabbed my shoulder. Suddenly, I felt energy coursing through my body, limitless energy. I opened my arms and closed my eyes, focusing on the pact God made with me: 'You can summon aids to this world' yet again.

"Well, now I think the portal is stable," said Hecate, raising her firm hand from my shoulder. "We are meeting the First Hero again, Liza," she cheered to Liza. I held back a choke. They asked me to focus on what little I knew about Lord First, but instead, my mind diverted to my best friend, the only guy I knew would have my back always on Earth and even on this different universe's planet, Charlie. I guess if he comes out, we will have to deal with the trio somehow, which might be difficult considering Charlie does not have powers and I do not know what my powers are.

"Well, let's just take it easy then," hinted Hecate as she snapped her fingers. Suddenly, chairs appeared around us to sit and relax in the chilly moonlight. But as soon as I tried

sitting down, I saw a haze in front of me. Something held my hand, and the next moment, something hit me hard on the cheek.

"What's happening?" I shouted as a drop of blood fell on my nose.

"So, heroes do actually bleed," said a voice in the middle of the night. It felt like I was hallucinating, yet I saw the trio struggling to stand on their feet. Something hit us, something so fast we could not even see it.

"Not this time!" yelled Hecate as she snapped her fingers. Our would-be assassin was now visible, caught in chains made of the night sky itself.

"Well, the cavalry is coming," he yelled. His voice triggered adrenaline in my body as I looked at the dunes behind us.

"There are around two dozen," said Liza grimly.

"If war is coming towards us, then I hold no reason to be democratic. I shall erase them all," declared Hecate. Immediately, everything around her turned dark. I knew what happened, as did my vision's magic index: the title Night's Sovereign was activated.

"We know nothing stands against you in this darkness but we—" The assassin's voice was cut short as his body imploded from Hecate's glance. She floated above us and, with a booming, bold voice, chanted, "Andrius Caelum Centaurus ari." Her voice was cut short, as was her magic, and she fell to the ground.

"We do have ways to kill you, you know," yelled the opposition leader as their men charged towards us.

"they have put up a barrier to neutralize whatever mana we push outward but I am sure basic mana manipulation and our skills can work" said Elfona , as I looked at her curious how she knows I saw her eyes glowing , I remember I was told that these eyes were special I simply understood it right now those were eyes of clairvoyance that's why she could tell if I am a hero or not , suddenly I felt as if my blood flow was stopped

forcefully as I was lifted and pushed to side "there is war going on here don't freeze looking on pretty women" yelled Liza as her red eyes glowed in the dark "You will never make it" she said as she opened her eyes even wider , I looked back and the so called cavalry was stopped in its track "sir hero I must implore you to attack as well" said Elfona , as I jumped towards the battle , some had guns for hand some had one laser eye it was a weird army but my human sense and morals were somehow turned off for so long I didn't felt anything when I killed am I turning into a monster regardless I jumped towards them quickly killed one by breaking there neck stealing there sword as I rushed forward "Killing you guys is boring now" I said , it was obvious I had level upped from my last battle this was effortless but as I left a trail of bodies behind me as I rushed towards the man in back who stood proud but as I cut through their ranks I felt a hand pulling me back I quickly turned around to see that those I have cut and those I have broken neck of are healing themselves and they aren't bleeding or anything it's like they are made of thick fiber and are reconnecting back "It's not only you who have privileges over death" said the man that stood behind it was as if he had control over these zombie like beings .Their bodies contorted and twisted, wires and sinew knitting back together with a grotesque speed, an unholy mockery of life. Limbs reattached themselves, faces reformed, and the lifeless eyes stared back with a malevolent spark. It was as if the very fabric of their being was rewoven, defying nature and death itself as there limbs fixed back up all I heard was a slight sound of buzzing it was as if my brain knew it was time for my punishment

"that's bad" I yelled as I realized I was being pulled back the dead hoard was over boarding me I guess I really didn't have the right to kill them and that was coming back to haunt me , they pulled me towards ground as they pulled my limbs trying to rip me limb by limb as I deserved

"GRAND SAGE MAGIC: - ATELEIOTO XIPHOS" Yelled a loud voice that felt like it was coming from everywhere, suddenly the dark starless night glow up in the haze of golden

****Charlie's Perspective: ****

"Movement will lead to the spell's activation, and the weather might not be suitable for you after that," I said, whimsically trying to hold back laughter. The battlefield they had summoned me to was filled with weaklings.

"A Grand Sage spell in this day and age? Who are you, grandpa?" said an unpleasantly brutish voice from the crest of the dune to the north. Before I could respond, the voice continued, "I suppose you are the pathetic mortal this hero has managed to summon. Pray tell, how did you bypass my anti-magic barrier? Is that skill enough to make a hero, or is that the Holy Kingdom's gizmo failure?"

In my long life, I had heard many taunts. They were customary in battle, but never before had I heard such fragile words. "What are you even babbling about?" I said, eyeing Hecate to fill me in. She simply bowed down before me, prostrating herself due to my mana's pressure.

"Oh, I thought heroes were given heightened senses. Is that all your body can achieve?" said the brutish voice. I gazed through the situation: there was a guy being pushed down by a horde of seemingly soldiers. It was not well-lit enough to see all the details. Well, it seems taunting was all I could do for another two seconds.

"Well, if you are so bold, then why don't you move?" I said, waiting for him to fall for it. Instead, Hecate rose from her knees and, still looking down, whispered, "Lord, that mortal over there is Jerry, the chosen hero of this era. It's been about 500 sun cycles since your last visit, and that person aligns himself with the Dictatorship."

That was all I needed to hear. "Lift mana pool's limit to 25% max," I said to my Index of Magic, a system that I had created. Looking at it now infuriated me. It showed I was not maxed out anymore. I needed one more level to max out, maybe due to my latest evolution, but I would never underestimate these levels. Each one is a 100% increase in at least physical strength if nothing else. Not like my mana can grow.

As I monologued, the trio—Hecate once again on the ground, Elfona lying gracefully on the sand, and Liza looking happy to prostrate herself—made a muffled noise. "Yeah, Liza, do you have something to say?" I asked curiously.

"Lord, the opponent exploded while you were tinkering with your index. All of them, even their boss," she replied. It wasn't as if I didn't know this; it was the very reason I unleashed 25% of my mana.

"I already tried using Cosmic Deicide on whatever power source he was tapping into as soon as he said 'anti-magic barrier.' I suppose those work like noise-canceling headphones from our universe, but you wouldn't understand that. Whatever the source itself seems to be non-traceable by Cosmic Deicide, which is weird, but most likely means that he and the freaks around him have given up their mana to receive supernatural gifts like physical transformations or other metaphysical abilities. Is that the gist of it?" I pointed the question towards Liza, who couldn't stop smiling.

"My lord, your intellect truly knows no bounds," she used the age-old technique of flattery students have used since the dawn of time, I would know I was there.

"Liza, quit that," I smiled. Then my vision focused. The 'summoned hero' hadn't moved his body yet. It seems being covered in blood of your enemies was out of fashion these days. I was sure he couldn't look at me, partly because my mana's aura was crushing him and partly because I made light refract more than usual to hide myself as his former friend. I did not want to give him an unpeaceful death.

"Who are you?" said Jerry, formerly a close friend. His voice trembled as if he had shred of humanity left in him but that was impossible this universe

"Come closer," I said. As he stepped a foot closer, my spell activated. The sky itself turned golden once again as a barrage of infinite unfinished blades attacked him like kamikaze drones ripping into his chest, his limbs and his eyes. It was not a sight for mortal eyes—hundreds of blades impaling your best friend is not a sight to see. But as it does to all, my humanity was not working; this universe was cursed that way.

For ten minutes, the blades impaled him repeatedly. They are called unfinished because they only finish when their enemy dies. I didn't see an inch of life left in him.

"Well, that was cinematic," I laughed loudly, as it was the only thing I could do.

"WHY DID YOU KILL HIM, CHARLIE, YOU MONSTER!" yelled Elfona, the ever-caring elf.

"Have some respect girl," I said calmly. It wasn't all her fault; she was biologically inclined to be nice. She was an elf, after all. "I had a duty to the universe I hailed from that I just completed. Now fill me in on what's happening here," I said to Liza as Hecate consoled her.

Hecate turned to me, "If I dare ask, husband, why did you choose to kill him so brutally? There was a merciful way. Why didn't you use your authority?"

Elfona rushed to check on the dead corpse of my former friend. "Well, I knew him as a human. He was pathetic. I am all you require and all you need," I said confidently because it was the truth with a smile to showcase how worthless he was for me.

"Can you explain how you overcame the anti-mana barrier sir?" asked Liza.

"That? Oh, the anti-mana barrier had a certain amount of mana it could destroy. I just over capped it," I replied.

"But us three combined have enough mana to destroy the world, they say," said Hecate, curious now. After all, she was a vampire; vampires don't mourn death.

"Well, that's how much stronger I am," I said with a smirk remembering a famous quote 'power corrupts , absolute power corrupts absolutely

Jerry's POV

It was as if they had just exploded. My enemies—those dead people who were managing to heal using cables for veins—burst into pools of blood. This new person seemed overwhelmingly strong. I couldn't believe it. He had this aura of pure darkness that obscured him from my view.

"Who are you?" I asked curiously, but my voice trembled. I was in shock. How could the mere presence of someone cause people to explode? It wasn't unheard of; Hecate had

managed to do it to one person, but this person could do it to everyone. Maybe I succeeded in calling the first hero.

"Come closer," said the voice welcomingly it had an effect on me as if I knew I should follow his commands, as it was defiantly masculine voice . I inched forward, but the sky suddenly turned golden. My vision blurred and switched to the index of magic. The world took on an aqua tint. A rectangular box appeared with a simple message: 'Do You Wish to Die? "No," I said, reading it in my mind. Suddenly, the golden haze of the sky that once protected me from that army turned against me; that haze turned into swords making me feel helpless as I couldn't even count them much less stop them, and they were coming for me. It was as if the voice that welcomed me wanted me dead. I closed my eyes', knowing death was impending. I didn't want to die so soon, not right after I got an offer to fix things.

"Death rejected." "Death rejected." "Death rejected."

A voice repeated this over and over again, so many times I lost count. It wasn't a voice I knew, but I wanted to believe it. Suddenly, I started hearing more voices. I heard Elfona yell, "WHY DID YOU KILL HIM, CHARLIE, YOU MONSTER!"

Charlie? But that was my friend, my closest ally. How could Elfona know him? More importantly, why Charlie even here? if he is here then why would Charlie kill me? How could my best friend cast such grand magic? Then I heard Hecate say, "If I dare ask, husband, why did you choose to kill him so brutally? There was a merciful way. Why didn't you use your authority?"

It was clear to my brain, but my heart refused to take it in my ears felt change in pressure itself my friend for so many years who knew everything about my life was a hero and I knew nothing about it how can that happen. Charlie was the first hero. He always had an aversion to sunlight and an eerie way of dressing, but that realization broke me. How could the only person who supported me at my worst be my murderer? Was he laughing when I was broken-hearted and crying? Maybe it was some other Charlie?

It wasn't the swords that were killing me; it was the betrayal. Maybe I was wrong, and this was some other Charlie. After all, Charlie is a common name. I tried opening my eyes, but sensed it was best to let them leave for now. Otherwise, that Charlie would kill me again, and I didn't know how immortal I was.

"I swear I was told this dude was supposed to be high immortal," said an eerily familiar voice. It was Charlie; that was for sure. It was my Charlie My closest friend. He was standing next to me. "Well, at least he has a grave of a thousand swords, whatever," he said as I heard a thud, and then everything fell silent.

But I wasn't foolish enough to let sound dictate if there was an enemy around me. Charlie's overwhelming aura still pressed upon my body as if it wanted a piece of me,

much like its master. After waiting for a while, the pressure faded gradually. I sneakily opened my eyes and confirmed no one was in the surrounding area. Charlie seemed to be gone with the trio—the so-called people who had my back. I guess in this world only power can be trusted.

I slowly tried to move, yet doing so was a monumental task. My body was pierced by a thousand swords, but for some reason, nothing hurt. Maybe I was already dead, and this was a dream, but I hoped it wasn't. As I put my hands into the night's cold sand, sinking them down so I could rise up, I noticed the swords vanished. It was as if not killing me had destroyed their purpose, and my wounds instantly healed.

Gathering enough strength to stand, I saw nearly a million golden swords stuck in the sand—a grand spell's aftereffect. "That'd be rather useful," I said, trying to pull one out of the ground for future use. But as soon as it left the sand, it vanished into thin air. Their sole purpose was to penetrate whatever they touched.

"Now what?" I yelled, knowing no one could hear me, or rather, I didn't care anymore. But before my anxiety could overwhelm me, I remembered the captain of the Hound Squad. He must have a fancy weapon. I rushed towards the pile of bodies, all torn into a thousand parts by the same person who killed me. His swords penetrated everything. "That bastard doesn't even care about death."

Then I remembered that for Charlie, death was always just a minor inconvenience. He never mourned death, nor did he care. Sitting in the classroom, I remembered how shocking it was when our classmate died in a car accident, but Charlie, sitting right next to me on the last bench, filed his pristine nails in eerie silence as if it was nothing. Now I know why—it was nothing to him. He was the 'hero' here, something he seemed to have forgotten to mention.

"I fucking hate it," I yelled as I dug through the dead parts of what I thought were humans. After digging up scraps, my hands covered in blood, I finally found something hard. My mood brightened up. At least I had a basic way to defend myself in the desert. And if Liza was right, there was a forest and mountains here. Maybe I could buy my time there, and then when Charlie finished off whatever fiend was ruining God's playground, we both could go home.

"So, I am useless then after all. I hate myself even more now. My hands have the blood of humans while I fight for monsters. Worse, I don't feel remorse for killing. Have I finally turned into a psychopath? Have I finally lost it?" I yelled at the sky, looking for answers. It was a chilly night, and I knew there weren't any answers carried by the wind for me.

"No, my boy. If you want to get back in that court, if you want to know why God summoned you, then you should follow me," said a raspy voice coming from due south. It was as if the universe sent me someone, I needed answers instead of the wind.

Damian's Perspective "Each generation of vampires has seen a hero come, grow in power, and leave, but we humans are fragile. Our life barely spans 120 sun cycles or years, as the heroes call it. We call them lord, we give them the status of king/queen and our protector, but no one except our Lord Third has actually been of help to us humans. She developed our technology, our magic, and our faith, making us stronger than those wretched vampires. We are now capable of scaring even the strongest of them. It shows that humanity is..." preached the Grand Saint. I, being an official officer of the Holy Kingdom, was forced to hear this ramble each day. That, along with my extended life, made this whole package less of a job and more of a seat warmer. My official job being negotiator for Seyleprus, the 'magical kingdom,' the pay being good, I have kept this boring job for years, but it was weary. Every day I think about making a difference by existing, even if my job is to negotiate with the Kingdom established by the First Hero, chosen by the Archangel of Destruction and Chaos, strongest of heroes. Blah blah, he isn't returning. He can't because if he does, he will turn into a full-fledged archangel. As I was wondering about this, a soldier came running. "Sire, SIRE, SIRE DAMIAN, you are needed. The First Hero, Lord Charlie the First, has returned. They are calling a diplomat for negotiation on the harm done to them and their soldiers by our technology," shouted the rushed soldier. There was no time to pity oneself. I had to run, I thought, before standing up from my seat in the church. I knew even the Pope wouldn't dare to stop me right now. Duty had finally called me. "Mana limiter lift 50%," I murmured as I rushed to my home to change clothes. As my royal carrier arrived, I saw the level of importance the Pope had given to this. Half of the armed militia had arrived to pick me up. Our forces, being the most technologically advanced in the whole world, are a force to reckon with, but that matters only if the rumors are false. If that soldier spoke the truth, no force on this supercontinent would be enough. The Authority of Destruction is still a horror story told by the church to keep us grounded, and I heard Charlie used Cosmic Deicide in his second coming, tearing through the concepts of creation to stop the creation of his own death. "Is it true?" I said, opening my ride's door, a royal carriage pulled by magical horses we developed on command of our Goddess 700 sun cycles ago. "Sire, we cannot confirm or deny the facts at this stage, but I can say for sure we have seen a mana influx large enough to say a hero has arrived," said the soldier. I could see from his expression, his eyes said it all—we were all dead. I myself have only been alive 300 sun cycles. Only the Pope understood the powers we are dealing with, and I don't see him all day. It looked like someone had decided to go inside his bunker today. "Well, I have lifted my limiter. Let's see what we have in store for today," I said, trying to look up and ready for the battlefield of a nation we were about to visit. I should be honest with myself; I haven't been this scared since I got to understand the church's workings. But as I was about to wander off into dreamland, "Damn, these chariots are too fast," I yelled as we stood in front of the largest castle in this entire world, the Castle of the Titan Prince, a place said to be in the middle of the world's mana flow and destiny. And I knew as I stepped out of my carriage that a malevolent being sits there. It wasn't

like anything I have ever felt before, the pressure itself was so overwhelming I could hardly believe that even outside this fortified city my forces were able to stand straight. But this was no time to dwell; I had the meet and greet with the devil himself. As I stepped forward, the whole city gleamed. These houses were well-built, simply screaming that they were nobility all around the castle itself. The castle was gothic-themed, made from magical stones that made it look like whatever the viewer could imagine the grandest to be. This whole castle, not only the castle but the whole kingdom, was nothing if not magic. Anyway, I didn't have time to study the composition of the rocks that made this castle, but I knew those ores were able to be traced by us even after so many years. Titans were truly beyond their time. As I approached the grand gateway, it loomed even larger than I had imagined. The gate was tall, with arches on the top that seemed to scrape the sky. But that was not all; the width and the length of this gate made me wonder who would even open it. It didn't seem practical. The door was an imposing barrier, made of dark, enchanted wood reinforced with intricate metalwork that shimmered with an eerie light. Each panel of the door was adorned with carvings of ancient battles and mythical creatures, their eyes seeming to follow me as I moved closer. The sheer size of the door was enough to make anyone feel insignificant, and the thought of what lay beyond it sent a shiver down my spine. The closer I got, the more I could feel the malevolent energy seeping through the cracks of the door. It was as if the castle itself was alive, watching and waiting for my next move. The air around me grew colder, and the weight of the atmosphere pressed down on me, making it hard to breathe. My heart pounded in my chest, each beat echoing in the silence that surrounded the castle. I could hear the faint whispers of ancient spells and curses, carried on the wind, reminding me of the power and danger that lay within these walls. but something inside of me decided it was best that I knock before whatever inside consider me a spy and attack because I knew that I was outclassed by every measurement of logic there is , as my hand tiny in comparison to the gate reached out something grabbed me from behind a hand on my shoulder , I didn't even had time to sense it "I am dead aren't I" I smirked not looking behind after all when it mattered the strongest solider of the holy kingdom the pillar of hope for the pope was nothing but a coward.

The Weight of Defiance

Damian's Perspective

"I am dead, aren't I?"

The atmosphere surrounding the castle was dense, almost stifling, reminiscent of the tension before an impending storm. It was daunting, and there I stood—merely a man with an official title—before the imposing gate. The whispers of the castle seemed to carry centuries of history: the legacies of heroes and the dark echoes of terrors long past, a testament to countless victories and agonizing defeats.

The monumental gate appeared to swell with each of my steps, growing more intimidating. Its surface was adorned with intricate carvings of mythical battles and ancient creatures, each of them seemingly scrutinizing me, assessing whether I was worthy of passage. As I approached closer, I caught sight of a lone guard—she was no ordinary sentinel. A vampire countess, majestic and commanding, clad in dark armor that shimmered with an almost unnatural luster. Unlike humans, inhumans like her had no need for anti-magic armaments—their very nature afforded them inherent resilience. She stood stoically, her face obscured by the cold gleam of her metal helmet, yet her aura was unmistakable. It made my skin crawl. It wasn't just her appearance but the sheer presence she exuded—something that felt both powerful and ancient.

My body acted before my mind could catch up, and I took a step backward. My throat was parched as I forced myself to meet her gaze through the darkness of her helmet's visor. Her voice, echoing from beneath, was deep and almost otherworldly, resonating as if it came from deep within the earth.

"State your purpose," she commanded.

"I... I am Damian, envoy of the Holy Kingdom," I managed to stammer, my voice betraying my unease. "I am here to meet with Lord Charlie."

She continued to stare, her silence amplifying my pounding heartbeat. After what seemed like an eternity, she nodded slowly, stepping aside. With her movement, the colossal gate began to open, seemingly of its own accord, groaning with the weight of ages, a sound that seemed to resonate beyond the physical plane.

Fear coiled around my chest like a vice. My thoughts whirled—this was it. I hadn't even begun to negotiate, and I already felt the creeping inevitability of fate. As the gate

creaked open, I could hear footsteps echoing from within the castle—a sign I was not alone. My heart pounded violently in my chest, teetering on the brink of panic. But instead of succumbing, I smirked, holding onto the bitter irony that characterized my situation.

"Not quite," came a voice—low, measured, with a hint of amusement. I turned and found myself face to face with a figure cloaked in deep red. Her features were obscured by the shadow of her hood, yet her eyes glowed faintly with a mixture of disdain and curiosity. Her grip on my shoulder was firm, almost as if to remind me that I held no power here.

"The First Hero is expecting you, Damian," she said, her voice devoid of warmth. The words struck me like a blow. The First Hero—Lord Charlie, the one who had defied even the gods, who had rewritten the natural order. My throat went dry; words eluded me. I simply nodded in acknowledgment.

She led me through the entryway, and my eyes widened at the grandeur of the castle's interior. It was vast, and yet there was a hollowness to it. A grand hall stretched before us, its dark stone walls illuminated by the cold flickering of blue flames. The ceiling loomed impossibly high, disappearing into shadow, and everything about the space suggested it existed beyond conventional notions of time and space.

Eventually, we reached what I assumed was the grand chamber. Instead of a grand throne, a raised platform held the Heart of the Titan King—the Titan of Fate—serving as a makeshift throne. It was nothing opulent, more akin to an enormous, irregular cushion, which Charlie used as his seat. Sitting there was Charlie, the First Hero. His posture was relaxed, almost casual, yet the energy that radiated from him was anything but. His eyes, sharp and filled with an unsettling depth, conveyed the knowledge and power of countless lifetimes.

He looked at me as if I were an interesting curiosity, perhaps something to be evaluated and dismissed.

"Ah, the envoy arrives," Charlie said, his voice controlled yet unyielding. He did not move from his seat, yet his gaze rooted me in place. "Let us get straight to business, Damian. I need you to account for your Kingdom's recent actions."

The weight of his words shattered the silence, and I was reminded, more than ever, of how different he was from us. He was beyond human, beyond anything I had ever encountered. Steeling myself, I tried to recall why I was there in the first place.

"Lord Charlie, I—" I began, my voice barely more than a whisper. "I come on behalf of the Holy Kingdom to—"

"Negotiate," he interjected, his tone flat. "Explain why your Kingdom is distributing anti-mana weaponry and destabilizing the balance. Do you truly believe that your words

carry weight here, Damian?" He leaned forward, his elbows resting lightly on his knees, his gaze piercing into mine.

I hesitated, carefully choosing my response. "We want to avoid further conflict—"

"Enough of the niceties," Charlie interrupted, his tone now sharper, his patience thinning. "Your Kingdom's actions—flooding the market with anti-mana weaponry—pose a direct threat. You're cornering those whose survival depends on magic, and this cannot stand." He paused, his eyes narrowing into slits. "Tell me, what measures are you prepared to take to rectify this?"

My heart sank, the enormity of the situation weighing on me. But I knew I couldn't let myself be seen as weak or powerless. Despite the fear gnawing at my insides, I gathered my mana, letting it swell within me, a flicker of my own power pushing back against the overwhelming force of Charlie's presence. I hoped it would at least demonstrate that I wasn't entirely helpless. The energy shimmered around me, a faint aura of defiance. What could I possibly offer that would appease someone like him—someone who had faced and bested deities? My throat tightened as I searched my mind, desperately trying to find a solution.

"Our Kingdom... we are willing to contribute all our resources—technology, allegiance. We would stand by your side, should you need—"

Charlie's laughter sliced through the room, chilling and resonant. "Do you think I need your allegiance? Your resources? Your technology is nothing more than a trinket to me." He rose from his chair, and though the movement was fluid, it commanded all attention. The air seemed to shift, growing colder, acknowledging his ascendancy. The blue flames along the walls flickered erratically, as if bending to his will.

An unseen force began to emanate from him, his mana spreading like an oppressive weight across the room, increasing the gravity of the very air. It pressed down on me, each particle demanding I acknowledge his superiority. My knees buckled, and I struggled against the mounting force, sweat forming on my brow. Breathing became labored, as though the simple act of drawing air was an impossible feat. It was not just magic—it was the sheer magnitude of his presence, an assertion of his dominance. He wanted me to understand how small I was in comparison, and I did. The flickering flames pulsed like a heartbeat, and time itself seemed to distort under the pressure. Despite the crushing weight, I focused, forcing my mana outward in an attempt to steady myself. It wasn't much compared to his vast ocean of power, but it was something—an ember of resistance against the storm.

"Do you honestly think your anti-mana weapons would be effective against me?" he asked, his tone almost amused, though it was edged with something darker. "These devices might pose a threat to those who lean entirely on magic, but I am beyond such

vulnerabilities. They are nothing but trivial distractions." His gaze narrowed, and the pressure intensified, bending the room to his will. My muscles ached, each breath harder than the last. Even the blue flames seemed burdened by the sheer force of his power. I knew that this was an assessment—a measure of my worth—and that my survival depended on how well I endured. My mana continued to pulse outward, a subtle but firm statement that I would not crumble without resistance. I could only hope that this show of resolve would be enough to earn his begrudging respect.

"You amuse me, Damian," he said, his gaze colder now. "But amusement alone is not enough. I require action. Your Kingdom must implement changes—immediately." He descended the platform, every movement deliberate, his presence commanding the entire space between us.

I stood there, instincts screaming at me to flee, but my feet refused to obey. "What, exactly, do you require of us, my lord?" I managed, forcing my voice to remain steady.

Charlie nodded once, curtly. "It's simple. I expect action, Damian. Cease the production of anti-mana weaponry at once. Furthermore, I demand the blueprints for these weapons be surrendered to me. If your Kingdom desires peace, then compliance is not optional." His eyes bore into mine, unblinking, making certain I comprehended the gravity of his demand.

His words were not a negotiation; they were an edict. The pretense of diplomacy had evaporated. It was clear that my task was to ensure the Holy Kingdom complied failure was not an option.

Taking a deep breath, I found some strength in my voice. "I will ensure that the Kingdom meets your demands, Lord Charlie."

The edges of his lips curved slightly, but not in a smile. He waved a dismissive hand. "Good. Now go. Relay my message and ensure that production halts immediately. I have no tolerance for delays or for excuses." He turned away, already losing interest in me, his attention drifting to matters far beyond my understanding.